

CITA01 – FOUNDATIONS OF CITY STUDIES SUMMER 2026

MAY 4TH, 2026

COURSE INSTRUCTOR: OLIVIA BERNARD



Tkaronto

Objectives

Tutorial
Schedule

Introductory
lecture on
City Studies

Introduction

Review Course
Assignments

INTRODUCTION

Contact

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Email Policy

- Please use your UofT email.
- CITA01 in the subject.
- 2 days, not including weekends.

THE 'BIG THEMES' OF THE COURSE

- The origins and evolution of cities
- Contemporary (global) urbanization
- Urbanization in the Global South vs. North
- Cities and globalization / Global cities
- Urban-regional space and morphology
- Urban culture, creativity & economy
- Urban inequality and social exclusion
- Urban politics and planning
- Urban design and urban outdoor space
- Sustainability and resilience of cities
- Artificial Intelligence and Urban Change

COURSE OBJECTIVES AND EXPECTED LEARNING OUTCOMES

- As the gateway course of the City Studies Program, the primary objective is to introduce students to classical and contemporary theories and ideas about cities and methods of inquiry in urban research from disciplines including anthropology, sociology, history, geography, economics, urban planning/design, and political science. By the end of the course, students will be able to
 - (1) Recall and describe key debates in urban scholarship.
 - (2) Describe the characteristics and limitations of various theoretical and methodological approaches
 - (3) Synthesize, evaluate, and reflect on scholarly contributions in urban research.

COURSE OBJECTIVES AND EXPECTED LEARNING OUTCOMES

- **Course Format**

The course consists of a weekly lecture (1 hour and 50 minutes each week) that will be delivered online.

- Tutorials will run for 5 weeks this semester.
- The amount of work for this class such as content review, tutorial attendance, readings, online activities, and assignments, is equivalent to roughly 3-5 hours per week. We encourage students to allocate this amount of time for the course each week.

COURSE READINGS

- ❖ All weekly materials are linked on Quercus, week by week.
- ❖ For all articles, they are labeled with the date and is the first link under each week.

COURSE EVALUATION

	Due Dates	Weight
Tutorial Participation and Attendance	Throughout	10%
Lecture Activity	Throughout	10%
Assignment 1 - Video or Annotated Podcast Mind Map and Outline	June 15	10%
Assignment 2 - Video or Annotated Podcast	July 27th	20%
Weekly Article Annotations	Throughout	20%
Final Examination	August Exam Period	30%
Total		100%

FINAL EXAMINATION

- Online timed synchronous exam - The final exam will be conducted online.
- You will be given a set 2-hour timed exam to complete.
- Additional information will be provided during the term

ASSIGNMENTS

- **Assignment Part 1** - Video or Annotated Podcast Mind Map and Outline

In preparation for assignment 2, you will be asked to complete an annotated mind map and rough outline. Additional details will be provided during the term.

- **Assignment Part 2** – Video or Annotated Podcast

You will be asked to complete an annotated podcast or video as your final assignment. An assignment outline will be provided and will detail the guidelines required.



TUTORIALS

- There will be 5 tutorials that will be conducted online. Each student is required to register for and attend the same tutorial throughout the term. Attendance is mandatory to obtain the 10% allotted.
- The tutorials will provide exam content review and skills development. The tutorial is a forum for students to learn about assignment requirements. Tutorials will also assist with preparing for the final exam. A portion of the tutorial marks will count towards attendance, and the remainder will be assessed as participation. 2% per tutorial.

Times and Links

1. Will be updated on both the home and modules pages.

LECTURE ACTIVITY



During weekly lectures, you will be provided with prompts to write very short responses based on the lecture for each week.



This will be done randomly during the lecture, and you will be asked to submit online for grading.



Lecture activities will account for 10% of your total grade.



Will be listed under the weekly modules



Lectures and Tutorials will not be recorded.

WEEKLY ANNOTATIONS

- Must be completed within one week to obtain the 2%.
- Let us review the expectations using an example in Quercus.

TUTORIALS

Tutorial Dates

- May 25
- June 8
- July 6
- July 20
- August 6

The schedule is on the Modules page and will be updated with links throughout before May 25th.

TKARONTO/TORONTO

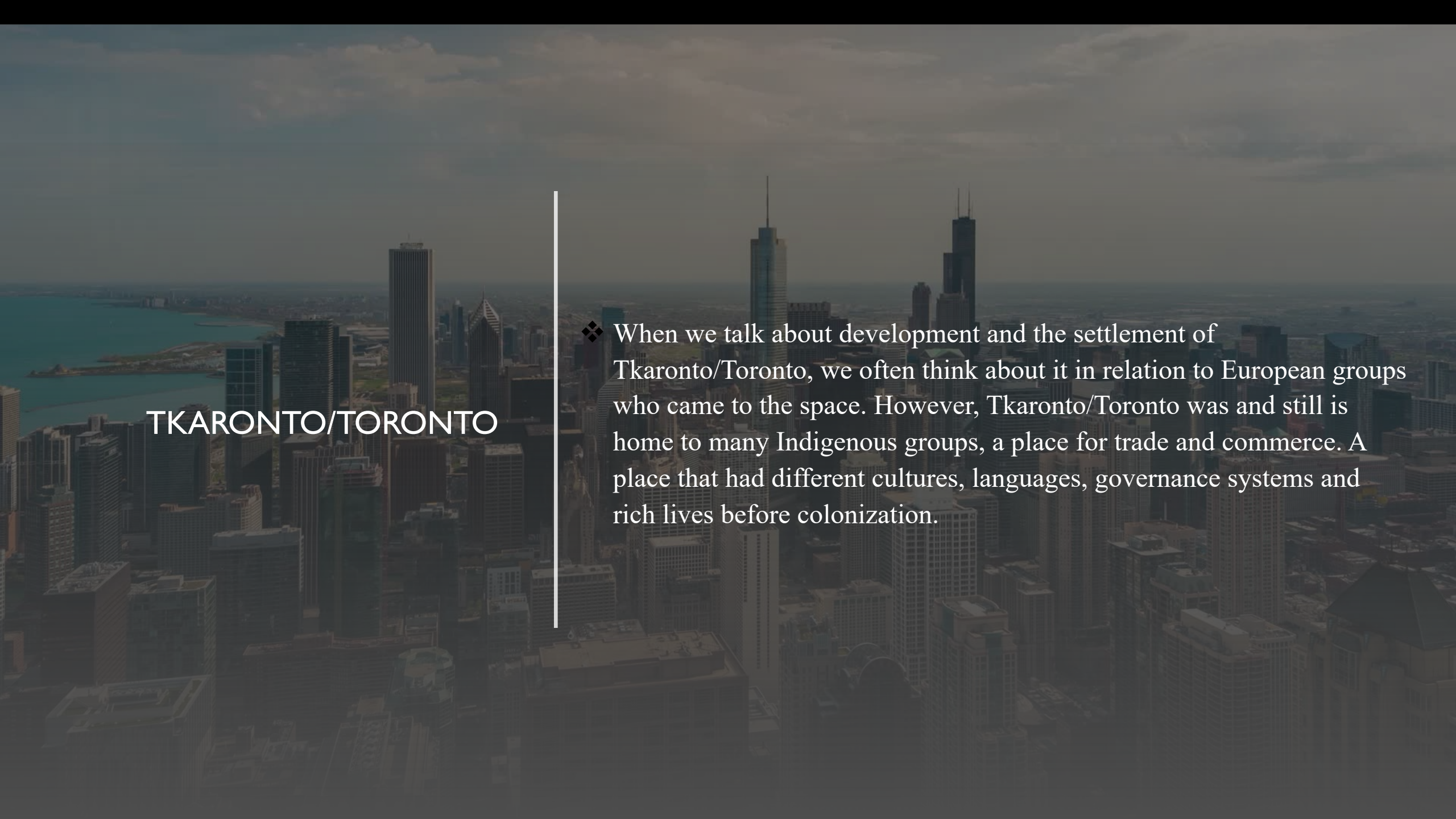
A Mohawk word - meaning the place in the water where the trees are standing. “Which is said to refer to the wooden stakes that were used as fishing weirs in the narrows of local river systems by the Haudenosaunee and Huron-Wendat”.



A part of the larger territory of Turtle Island, the Indigenous word used to describe North America

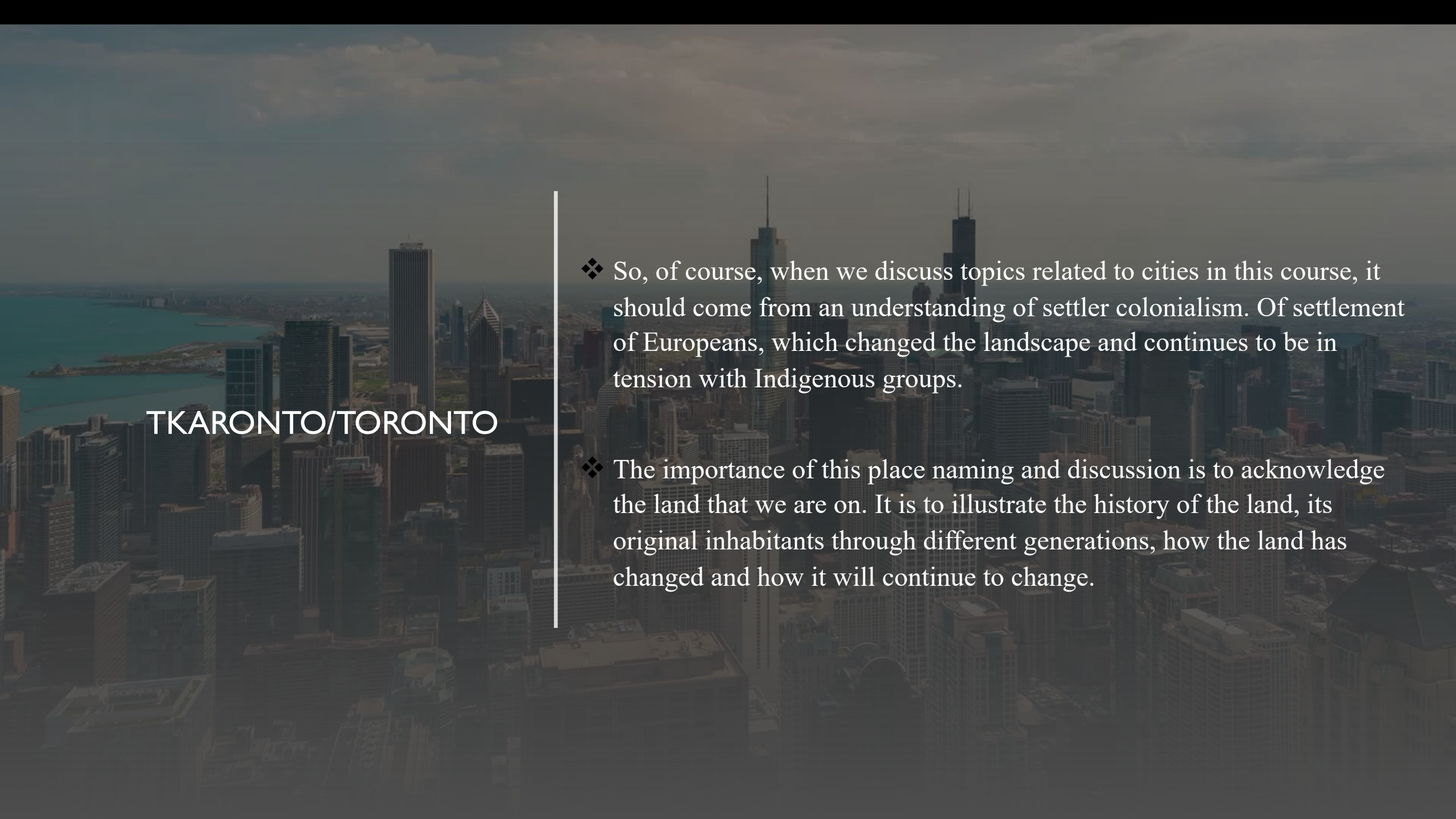


A place where for thousands of years, various Indigenous groups lived, and others passed through. Groups such as the Wendat, Anishnaabeg, Haudenosaunee, Métis and Mississaugas of the Credit

An aerial photograph of the Chicago skyline, showing numerous skyscrapers and the city's layout. Lake Michigan is visible on the left side of the image. The sky is overcast with grey clouds. The text is overlaid on the image in a white, sans-serif font.

TKARONTO/TORONTO

- ❖ When we talk about development and the settlement of Tkaronto/Toronto, we often think about it in relation to European groups who came to the space. However, Tkaronto/Toronto was and still is home to many Indigenous groups, a place for trade and commerce. A place that had different cultures, languages, governance systems and rich lives before colonization.



TKARONTO/TORONTO

- ❖ So, of course, when we discuss topics related to cities in this course, it should come from an understanding of settler colonialism. Of settlement of Europeans, which changed the landscape and continues to be in tension with Indigenous groups.
- ❖ The importance of this place naming and discussion is to acknowledge the land that we are on. It is to illustrate the history of the land, its original inhabitants through different generations, how the land has changed and how it will continue to change.

INTRODUCTION TO CITY STUDIES

WHY STUDY CITIES FROM AN **INTERDISCIPLINARY
PERSPECTIVE?**

INTRODUCTION TO CITY STUDIES

WHY STUDY CITIES FROM AN INTERDISCIPLINARY PERSPECTIVE?

- ❖ City and regional planning and urban studies departments are generally interdisciplinary and have **faculty trained in a variety of academic disciplines** and professional fields.
- ❖ Regardless of whether or not they have interdisciplinary major or minors, most universities **encourage research and teaching that crosses disciplinary boundaries**

INTRODUCTION TO CITY STUDIES

WHY STUDY CITIES FROM AN INTERDISCIPLINARY PERSPECTIVE?

- ❖ The strength of interdisciplinary approaches is that, done properly, an interdisciplinary approach provides for a richer, more holistic, more **varied understanding of multiple dimensions of the phenomena being studied** than a study from a single disciplinary perspective.
- ❖ The weakness of interdisciplinary approaches is that they **may become so loose and standardless** that they lack intellectual rigor

INTRODUCTION TO CITY STUDIES

WHAT RESEARCH METHODS DO URBAN
SCHOLARS USE?

INTRODUCTION TO CITY STUDIES

DIMENSIONS OF URBAN RESEARCH

Scholars who study cities use both quantitative and qualitative research methods. Both approaches can contribute to understanding cities. The best urban research designs often combine both quantitative and qualitative research

- Quantitative research
- Qualitative research
- Mixed-methods research
- Cross-sectional vs. longitudinal research
- The centrality of (geographical) space

INTRODUCTION TO CITY STUDIES

THE “HOW?” OF RESEARCH SOME COMMON METHODS IN URBAN RESEARCH

- Bibliographical research / Library research
- Archival research
- News media analysis / Content analysis of texts
- Policy analysis
- Observation / Field research
- Interviewing
- Surveys
- Statistical / quantitative research
- Focus groups
- Community-based and participatory methods
- Geographic Information Science
- And others.... (think about “methods” when you read research articles for this course)

Next Steps

The Origins and Evolution of Cities

- Childe, V. Gordon. 2015 [1950]. “The Urban Revolution.” Pp. 30-38 in The City Reader.
- Davis, Kingsley. 2015 [1965]. “The Urbanization of the Human Population.” Pp 19-29 in The City Reader.

